

Two Anointings, Not One

A Defense of Treating Matthew 26:6–13 and John 12:1–11 as Separate Events

From Paul — to a friend who reads carefully and disagrees graciously

Revision: May 3, 2026 — Updated to incorporate further textual study

Where We Agree Before We Disagree

Brother, I want to say up front that the position you are taking is not a careless one. Serious students of Scripture have held it for a long time, and the case has real footing. The two accounts share a village (Bethany), a costly fragrance, an objection about the poor, a response from Jesus tying the act to His burial, and the unforgettable line, “You always have the poor with you.” Anyone who notices those overlaps and asks, “Could this be one event?” is doing what a careful reader is supposed to do.

And your specific point about the pound of pure nard is a fair one. Twelve ounces is more than enough to anoint both the head and the feet at the same sitting, so quantity alone is not what decides this question. I grant that. If the only difference between the accounts were head versus feet, I would not feel the weight I feel.

But I did not land on two events because of one detail. I landed there because, when I lined the accounts up against each other and read them in their immediate context, their chapter context, and the context of the final week, the discrepancies kept stacking. By the time I had counted them, the burden of explanation had clearly shifted to the harmonizing reading, not the plain reading. What follows is the case, laid out so you can weigh it and tell me where you think it falls short.

The Two Accounts, Side by Side

Matthew 26:6–13 (parallel: Mark 14:3–9). Setting: Bethany, in the home of Simon the leper. An unnamed woman comes with an alabaster vial of very costly perfume and pours it on Jesus’ head while He reclines at the table. “The disciples” (Mark says “some”) become indignant about the waste — the perfume could have been sold for “a high price” (Mark: “over three hundred denarii”) and given to the poor. Jesus defends her: she has done a good deed, she has anointed His body for burial, and “wherever this gospel is preached in the whole world, what this woman

has done will also be spoken of in memory of her.” Time anchor: “after two days the Passover is coming” (Matt. 26:2; cf. Mark 14:1).

John 12:1–1. Setting: Bethany, six days before the Passover, at the home where Lazarus is reclining at the table and Martha is serving. Mary takes a pound of very costly pure nard and anoints Jesus’ feet, wiping them with her hair; the house is filled with the fragrance. Judas Iscariot is named as the objector, and John adds that Judas was a thief who used to pilfer from the money box. Jesus answers, “Let her alone, so that she may keep it for the day of My burial. For you always have the poor with you, but you do not always have Me.” Time anchor: “six days before the Passover” (John 12:1), with the Triumphal Entry on “the next day” (John 12:12).

First Difficulty: The Chronology Is Explicit on Both Sides

This is the heaviest weight in the case, so I want to state it plainly. Both John and Mark anchor their account with a specific time marker.

John 12:1 places the dinner six days before Passover, and 12:12 places the Triumphal Entry on “the next day.” That puts John’s anointing the night before the entry into Jerusalem.

Mark 14:1 says, “Now the Passover and Unleavened Bread were two days away,” and Mark 14:3 follows immediately with, “And while He was in Bethany at the home of Simon the leper, reclining at the table, there came a woman ...” Matthew 26:2 sets the same window: “After two days the Passover is coming.”

Between John’s timestamp and Mark’s timestamp lie the Triumphal Entry, the Temple cleansing, the cursing of the fig tree, the day of controversies, and the Olivet Discourse. That is four days of dense, well-attested events. To make these one anointing, somebody’s timestamp has to give way. There is no third option.

Your Response: “Matthew Wrote Non-Chronologically Here”

I understand that the move you are making is to say Matthew lifted the event out of its actual time slot and placed it next to Judas’s betrayal for thematic reasons — to show what tipped Judas over the edge. That is a recognized harmonization, and the principle behind it is real: Matthew does arrange topically in some places (the Sermon on the Mount, the miracle cycle of chapters 8–9). So I am not dismissing the principle. I am asking whether this passage is one of the cases where it applies. I do not think it is, for five reasons.

1. The time anchor is in Mark, not just Matthew

If Matthew alone had placed the anointing after the Olivet Discourse with no time marker, the relocation argument would have real footing. But Mark anchors the same event with “two days away” and then ties the anointing to that window with a genitive absolute (“and while He was in Bethany ...”). The grammar locks the event into Mark’s timeframe. So either Mark also relocated it — and Mark is the Gospel least likely to abandon chronology, the “and immediately” Gospel — or both Synoptic writers placed the anointing where it actually happened. The argument cannot rest on Matthew alone, because the anchor sits in Mark’s text just as firmly.

2. The thematic payoff Matthew supposedly intended is not delivered

The argument says Matthew relocated the anointing to highlight what triggered Judas. But notice: in Matthew, Judas is not named at the anointing. Matthew says “the disciples” were indignant (26:8). Mark says “some” were (14:4). Neither writer mentions Judas as the objector. John, the one writing chronologically by everyone’s admission, does name Judas. So if Matthew’s purpose in relocating the event were to spotlight Judas, the natural editorial move would have been to name Judas — and Matthew did not. The supposed reason for the relocation is not actually present in the relocated text. That is a significant weakness.

3. Matthew’s chronological care elsewhere in chapter 26 is high

Look at how Matthew tracks time through this chapter: “after two days” (26:2), “on the first day of Unleavened Bread” (26:17), “when evening came” (26:20), “then Jesus came with them to a place called Gethsemane” (26:36), “while He was still speaking” (26:47). He is sequencing carefully. To say he abandoned chronology only for the anointing — and dropped it inside an explicit “two days before Passover” frame where it did not actually belong — is to attribute to him an editorial choice that runs against the grain of his own chapter.

4. The relocation explanation is not the simplest one

The text already explains Judas’s betrayal without needing to import an event from four days earlier. Watch the structure of Mark 14: priests plot (14:1–2) → woman lavishly anoints Jesus at Simon’s house (14:3–9) → Judas goes to the priests (14:10–11). The trigger does not need to be Mary’s anointing six days back. It can be this second public, head-anointing event, in which Jesus accepts an extravagant act and openly speaks of His burial as imminent. The narrative is

self-sufficient. We do not have to relocate John's account to make sense of Judas's decision; the Synoptic anointing supplies a perfectly adequate trigger on its own.

5. The methodological cost is high

If we adopt as a default move "When two accounts conflict in time, one writer must have abandoned chronology to make a thematic point," that tool becomes available everywhere, and Scripture starts losing its concrete historical anchoring at exactly the points where the writers were most careful to give us anchors. "Six days before Passover" and "two days before Passover" are not vague phrases. They are deliberate. We owe it to the writers not to override their explicit timestamps unless the text itself signals that it is doing something non-chronological. There is no such signal here.

Second Difficulty: The Discrepancies Are Not the Kind That Drift Between Retellings

Even if I granted the chronology question (which I do not), I would still have to explain a list of differences that do not normally vary when one event is told three ways. Take them one at a time.

The host

Matthew/Mark: the home of Simon the leper. John: the home where Lazarus is reclining and Martha is serving. These cannot easily be the same house. Lazarus and Mary and Martha lived as a family unit (John 11); their home is identified by who is at the table. Simon the leper is identified by his condition and his name. To collapse them, the harmonizer has to invent a connection the text does not give — "maybe Simon was Lazarus's father," "maybe the dinner was at Simon's but Martha was helping serve." Possible, but speculative. The texts as written give two different households.

The woman — and the disambiguator John gives us

Matthew/Mark: an unnamed woman. John: Mary specifically, a woman so well known that John assumes the reader recognizes her without further introduction. And here is the detail I want you to weigh carefully. Before John ever describes the John 12 anointing, he reaches back into John 11 and identifies Mary this way:

“It was the Mary who anointed the Lord with ointment, and wiped His feet with her hair, whose brother Lazarus was sick.” — John 11:2

Notice what John does not say. He does not identify her merely as “the Mary who anointed the Lord.” He identifies her specifically as the Mary who anointed the Lord with ointment and wiped His feet with her hair. The second clause is doing the entire identifying work — and it points exclusively to the act recorded in John 12. The unnamed woman at Simon the leper’s house poured perfume on His head (Matthew 26:7; Mark 14:3). She did not wipe His feet with her hair. That detail is not incidental — it is the single most distinctive feature of Mary’s act, and John uses precisely that feature to identify her.

Far from arguing for one event, John 11:2 reads as if John already knew of more than one anointing and was deliberately pointing the reader to the right one: which Mary, which anointing? The foot one. The hair one. Not the head one at Simon’s house. The identifier only makes sense as a disambiguation if there is something to disambiguate from.

It would also be very strange for Matthew and Mark, knowing the act would be told “wherever this gospel is preached ... in memory of her,” to leave Mary’s name out if it had been Mary. The simpler reading is that the unnamed woman at Simon’s house was not Mary.

Head versus feet

You are right that a pound of nard is sufficient to anoint both, so this detail alone does not settle it. But the meanings of the two acts are different, and each meaning fits its setting. Anointing the head carries royal-priestly-burial weight — kings and priests were anointed on the head (1 Sam. 16:13; Lev. 8:12; Ps. 133:2), and bodies were anointed for burial. That fits perfectly with the unnamed woman’s act two days before Passover, where Jesus says, “She did this to prepare Me for burial.” Anointing the feet, with hair-wiping, is something else — a deliberate inversion of social expectation, an act of personal worship from someone who has sat at His feet to learn (Luke 10:39) and watched her brother walk out of a tomb at His word. Mary’s act fits Mary. The unnamed woman’s act fits the public, kingly-burial moment on the eve of betrayal. They are not redundant; they are complementary. They were not preserved by the Spirit by accident.

The objector — and a note about the price

Matthew: “the disciples.” Mark: “some.” John: Judas specifically, with the editorial note that he was a thief who used to pilfer from the money box. If these are one event, why does John single

out Judas while Matthew and Mark generalize? A harmonizer can answer, “Judas spoke first and the others joined in,” and that is possible. But it is one more thing the harmonizing reading has to assume that the text does not actually say.

There is also a smaller detail worth noting here. The harmonizing argument sometimes appeals to the price tag — “three hundred denarii” (John 12:5) and “over three hundred denarii” (Mark 14:5) — as a fingerprint identifying one event. But notice who supplied the appraisal. In John, it was Judas himself, the keeper of the money box and a thief (John 12:6). In Mark, it was “some” at Simon’s house — a group in which Judas was certainly present, since he was one of the twelve and only hours away from going to the priests. The matching number is the consistent behavior of a consistent appraiser at two events, not a textual fingerprint requiring a single event. The man who thought about money for a living, and stole from the box, gave a similar valuation for similar vials of the same imported commodity.

The memorial saying

Matthew and Mark close with, “Wherever this gospel is preached ... what this woman has done will also be spoken of in memory of her” (Matt. 26:13; Mark 14:9). John does not record this saying — strange, since John of all the writers loves to quote Jesus’ declarations about future and eternal things. The simplest explanation is that the saying belongs to a different occasion than the one John records.

On the Burial Preparation — Why Two Anointings Is Not Redundant

If the harmonizing reading presses you with the idea that a second pre-burial anointing would be redundant, the text itself answers the objection. Burial preparation for Jesus did not happen in a single moment — it happened in stages, with multiple people, across multiple days, with multiple substances. Lay them out:

— Mary anoints His feet at the supper where Lazarus reclined (John 12:3).

— The unnamed woman pours pure nard on His head at Simon the leper’s house (Matthew 26:7; Mark 14:3).

— Nicodemus and Joseph wrap His body with about a hundred pounds of myrrh and aloes at the tomb (John 19:39–40).

— The women buy spices, prepare them, rest on the weekly Sabbath, and come at dawn the first day of the week with what they have prepared (Mark 16:1; Luke 23:56; Luke 24:1).

Four distinct stages of burial-related anointing or spice preparation. The Spirit considered none of it redundant. If Nicodemus's hundred pounds and the women's additional spices both qualify as preparing the body for burial, then a foot-anointing by Mary and a head-anointing by an unnamed woman during the days before His death are well within the same pattern.

"Beforehand" in Mark 14:8 describes timing relative to His death — not exclusivity relative to other acts. The word does no work for the one-event reading.

Notice also that the two pre-death anointings cover different parts of the body. Mary anointed the feet — the feet that had walked toward the cross. The unnamed woman poured on the head — the head that would soon wear the crown of thorns. Two acts. Two parts of the body. Both pre-burial preparation. Both received by Jesus on their own terms.

Third Difficulty: Each Writer Has Embedded His Account in a Tightly Constructed Chapter

Mark and Matthew place the anointing as the deliberate foil to Judas's betrayal. Priests plot (Mark 14:1–2). A woman pours out something worth a year's wages on Jesus' body for burial (14:3–9). Judas sells Jesus' body for thirty pieces of silver (14:10–11). The structure is doing theological work right where it sits. To pull the anointing out of that position is to break Mark's structure for the sake of harmonization.

John places his anointing in a different but equally deliberate structure: chief priests issuing arrest orders (11:57) → Mary's anointing six days before Passover (12:1–8) → the Lazarus crowd and the priests plotting against Lazarus (12:9–11) → the Triumphal Entry the next day (12:12–19). John's anointing is the quiet, intimate moment of recognition before the public acclamation. It is not interchangeable with the public, kingly head-anointing at Simon's house. Each chapter loses something if its anointing is removed.

Fourth Consideration: Multiple Anointings of Jesus Are Already Documented

Luke 7:36–50 records a clearly distinct anointing earlier in Jesus' ministry, in Galilee, at the house of Simon the Pharisee (a different Simon), by a sinful woman who wets His feet with her tears, wipes them with her hair, kisses them, and anoints them with perfume. Nobody seriously

argues this is the same event as either John 12 or Matthew 26. So Scripture has already given us textual precedent for multiple anointings being narrated separately. We are not inventing a category. We are recognizing one Scripture itself has already established.

If anointing happened at least twice in Jesus' ministry without scholarly objection, the prior probability that it happened a third time during the most concentrated, devotion-rich week of His life is not low. It is, frankly, what we should expect.

Where the Burden of Proof Lies

This is what I would ask you to weigh. The two-event reading requires nothing of the interpreter except reading what is written: two timestamps, two hosts, two women (one named, one unnamed), two body parts, two objectors, one memorial saying recorded by two writers and one not. Every detail fits.

The one-event reading, even in its most careful form, requires the interpreter to do all of the following:

- Override one Gospel writer's explicit time anchor (either John's "six days before" or the Synoptics' "two days before").
- Assume Mark abandoned his usual chronological care, despite his grammar locking the event into the two-day window.
- Assume the relocation served to highlight Judas, even though Matthew and Mark do not name Judas as the objector.
- Harmonize Simon the leper's house with Lazarus's household by inventing a connection the text does not give.
- Explain why Mary's name appears in John but not in Matthew or Mark, on the very occasion that Jesus says will be told "in memory of her."
- Explain why John 11:2 identifies Mary specifically by the foot-and-hair act — a feature absent from the Matthew/Mark account.
- Explain why Matthew and Mark generalize the objection to "the disciples" / "some" when, on the harmonizing view, they knew it was Judas specifically.

— Account for the memorial saying being included by Matthew and Mark and absent from John.

Any one of these moves is a stretch. All eight together are more than the text can carry without strain. The simpler reading — the one that takes both timestamps at face value, lets the differing details stand, and recognizes that two distinct anointings happened during the final week — honors the text the writers actually gave us.

How the Two Events Fit Together

Reading the week as a whole, here is what the texts let us see. Six days before Passover, on the eve of the Triumphal Entry, Jesus comes to Bethany. Mary — who has sat at His feet to learn, who has heard Him say her brother would rise — takes a pound of pure nard and pours it on His feet, wiping them with her hair. The fragrance fills the house. Judas, whose heart is already turned, objects. Jesus defends her, ties the act to the day of His burial, and the next morning rides into Jerusalem as King.

Four days later, after the Temple cleansing, the controversies, and the Olivet Discourse, Jesus is again at Bethany — this time at the house of Simon the leper. An unnamed woman comes with an alabaster vial of very costly perfume and pours it on His head. The disciples object as a group; Judas, whose betrayal is now hours away, is among them. Jesus defends her, calls it a beautiful thing, says she has anointed His body for burial, and promises that her act will be told wherever the gospel is preached. Within hours Judas is at the chief priests' door.

Two acts. Two women. Two settings. Both prophetic. Both honored. The Spirit preserved both because both matter, and the Gospel writers who recorded each one knew what they were doing.

In Closing

I am not asking you to agree with me on every detail of this. You have previously told me that we could disagree on the days. I am asking you to weigh the cost of the harmonizing reading against the cost of the plain reading. The harmonizing reading buys a single event at the price of overriding explicit timestamps, generalizing away named details, and assuming editorial decisions the writers did not flag. The plain reading buys two events at the price of — nothing. It costs the text nothing. It explains every difference. It honors every timestamp. And it does not

require us to assume Matthew, Mark, or John would arrange material in a way that would mislead readers about when something happened.

If man says one thing and the text says another, I owe my allegiance to the text. That is not stubbornness; it is the only honest place to stand when we treat Scripture as the inspired Word of God. I have tried diligently to go only where the text led me, and I will continue to stand there until someone shows me a reading of the text — not a reading of our assumptions about the text — that requires otherwise.

With real respect for the care you bring to these questions, and with thanks for sharpening my thinking,

Paul

P.S. Intentionally or inadvertently, you have caused me to spend much more time with this than I did originally, and I am more convinced than ever — not only of the two separate events discussed here, but also of the timing of that final week of the Lamb. I firmly believe that the crucifixion and the days leading up to it are a literal fulfillment of the days leading up to and the killing of the Passover lamb in Exodus 12.